

Mother to Son

- by Langston Hughes

The following is a poem by Langston Hughes about life's lessons from a mother to her son. Read the poem and then its explicit meaning in the paragraph that follows.



Well, son, I'll tell you:
Life for me ain't been no crystal stair.
It's had tacks in it,
And splinters,
And boards torn up,
And places with no carpet on the floor -
Bare.
But all the time
I've been a-climbin' on,
And reachin' landin's,
And turnin' corners,
And sometimes goin' in the dark
Where there ain't been no light.
So boy, don't you turn back.
Don't you set down on the steps
'Cause you finds it's kinder hard.
Don't you fall now -
For I've still goin', honey,
I've still climbin',
And life for me ain't been no crystal stair.



Explicit Meaning

In the poem above, the poet **Langston Hughes** speaks from the point of view of a mother who advises her son about life. Life for her has not been a crystal staircase. At times, it has been bare, with splinters, tacks, boards torn up and uncovered places with no carpet on the floor. But she has been climbing and turning corners even when there has been no light. She tells her son that he shouldn't sit back on the stairs or fall or turn back, even when the going gets hard, because she is still going strong and climbing, and so must he.